certainty. Don't count Assam's civic-minded elephants as a case of permanent adaptation. "They have no choice," says Y.V. Jhala, wildlife biologist and former dean of Wildlife Institute of India. "Elephants live long lives, say 70 years. A habitat change won't kill the present generation. There will be friction but it will adapt and survive, even eating crops to stave off starvation. But the next generation will not flourish," he says. It's an impending tragedy. WWF estimates that no more than 15 per cent of the historical roaming range of Asia's elephants exists today. Consequently, 80 per cent of them live outside protected areas. In India, a mid-2023 estimate put their numbers at 30,000. But the findings of the first scientific elephant census, wrapped up by October 2024, have been mysteriously kept under wraps by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC). The elephant in the room, perhaps?

Tigers, meanwhile, are a famous conservation success story: a healthy annual population growth rate of 6 per cent, pugmarks across India, poaching largely controlled. But, while 65 per cent of India's tigers are ordinarily resident in reserves, a 2020 study found nearly 60 per cent of their habitat to be less than five kilometres from a road, which drives down their prey base by over 20 per cent. In fact, extirpated from over 90 per cent of their historical range, today, as per Jhala's latest study published in the *Science* journal in February 2025, tigers coexist with 66 million people in India. Are they getting 'tolerant' of human presence? "Big cats are adaptable. Tigers are being found living amidst humans, at low densities. Lions are found even at high densities," says Jhala. Another conservationist names the phenomenon, saying India's wild Asiatic lions are actually not 'wild' anymore. Just one gene pool, zooed into just one landscape, with overarching human presence in and around, the Asiatic lion has embarked on an evolution bus that has made them relatively docile, to the point of being dependent on human presence. A study co-authored by Jhala, published in *Conservation Biology* in November 2024, records the 'taming' of Asiatic lions. "Locals offer their livestock as bait to conduct illegal lion shows," it says. The government compensates them for the loss of livestock, and the tourism money is good.

Everyone heard of the vulture's shocking drop from a few millions in the early '90s to the verge of extinction. But the easy urbanisation of its close cousin, the black kite, has fascinated researchers. Nishant Kumar of the Wildlife Institute of India has studied a dense population of the Black Kite Milvus breeding within Delhi. "The species managed to exploit an extreme urban environment, customising their behaviour to human behaviour. Black kite populations, for instance, were stable over five decades in Muslim settlements where feeding meat was a religious ritual. Hence, rather than a nuisance to avoid, humans were a keenly targeted foraging resource," Kumar says. They dwindled in tree-less areas with no feed, though. Even some of the lakhs of migratory birds that arrive in India in winter are showing signs of adaptation. Among them, the Greater and Lesser flamingos are tagged as about the most shy. But in 2021, behind Bhavnagar airport, Lesser Flamingos made a nesting attempt in a shallow wetland by the highway, with vehicles passing by. An attempt that's given hope to conservationists. This was 300 km away from its traditional nesting grounds—"itself a record, except for a 1994 sighting in Porbandar", say researchers Kandarp and Prashant Andharia.



AT HOME A flock of Lesser Flamingos in Surat

EVEN SOME OF THE LAKHS OF **MIGRATORY BIRDS THAT ARRIVE IN INDIA EVERY WINTER** ARE SHOWING SIGNS OF ADAPTATION

A NEW EVOLUTION?

Are we then looking at a phase of coexistence? "Countries like India cannot really stop human-wildlife conflict. Barring some places, wildlife is thriving—because of the resources humans have made available," says conservation biologist Abi Tamim Vanak of ATREE. "Jackals and jungle cats thrive in agricultural fields; they feed on poultry. Scavengers like hyenas, wolves and leopards throng on human refuse. They appear to have adapted. They have no choice." Wildlife has always lived with humans in rural areas. The coexistence of humans and leopards in Jawai, Pali district of Rajasthan, is part of local folklore. They live in caves in the rocky scrub forests, stroll around temples and highways, without any incidents of human attacks.

Of course, expecting such idyllic charm across the board is too preposterous an idea. The present moment is decidedly not one of utopia but of conflict, with fatalities on both sides. For the fauna, there's accidental mortality due to electrocution, road and rail collisions—not to speak of deliberate killings by poisoning, lynching and even crude bombs, the last being Kerala's answer to wild boars. Disease transmission from livestock and dogs to wildlife is another threat. The losses faced by human communities, often for no fault of theirs, adds a razor's edge to the equation. But if the animals are adapting, a quotient of evolution in human thinking too is warranted, especially at policy levels. The answer may lie in India's old cultural ethos. ■